



CORTEX SETUP GUIDE

BUILD YOUR CORTEX

From AI Strategy Canvas to a living, version-controlled knowledge base
your team and your AI both work from.

Hawthorne Racing · July 2026 · hawthorneracing.com

GETTING STARTED

OVERVIEW

This guide walks you through standing up a **Cortex** — a version-controlled knowledge base that your team and your AI both work from. There are three routes in:

THREE WAYS TO SET UP

PATH	USE IT WHEN
A — Build from scratch	You're starting clean and designing your organisation's structure yourself.
B — Start from the template	You copy the Hawthorne Racing demo Cortex and refit it to your own content.
C — Join an existing Cortex	Your organisation already has one and you need it on your machine.

Everyone does **Part 1** (the tools) and **Part 4** (wiring in Claude Code). Parts 2 and 3 depend on your path. Follow the steps in order — don't skip ahead.

PART 1 • INSTALL THE TOOLS

You'll do this once per machine. If you already have Git or Node.js, skip those steps.

STEP 1 — INSTALL GIT

Git tracks every change to every file in your Cortex. It's what turns a pile of documents into an asset with a history.

- 1. Go to `https://git-scm.com/download/win`
- 2. Download the installer and run it. Click Next through everything using default settings.
- 3. For the default editor, pick whatever you like (Notepad is fine).
- 4. For PATH, choose "Git from the command line and also from 3rd-party software".
- 5. Finish the install, then open a new PowerShell and verify:

```
git --version
```

You should see something like `git version 2.44.0` . If you do, Git is installed.

PART 1 · INSTALL THE TOOLS

STEP 2 – INSTALL NODE.JS

Node.js runs Claude Code. You need version 18 or higher.

1. Go to <https://nodejs.org> and download the LTS version (the big green button).
2. Run the installer with default settings, then close and reopen your terminal.
3. Verify Node and npm (npm ships with Node):

```
node --version  
npm --version
```

You should see `v20` or higher, and a version number for npm. Both working means you're good.

STEP 3 – INSTALL PYTHON

Python runs graphify, which indexes your Cortex into a knowledge graph so Claude doesn't have to read every file every session.

1. Go to <https://www.python.org/downloads/> and download the latest version.
2. **Important:** on the first installer screen, check "Add python.exe to PATH".
3. Click Install Now, reopen your terminal, and verify:

```
python --version
```

STEP 4 – INSTALL CLAUDE CODE

```
npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code
```

Wait for it to finish, then verify with `claude --version`. A version number means Claude Code is installed.

STEP 5 – GET A GITHUB ACCOUNT

Your Cortex lives on GitHub — that's what makes it shared, backed up, and available on every machine you work from.

1. Go to <https://github.com/signup> and create a free account (skip if you have one).
2. Use your work email if this Cortex belongs to your organisation.

PART 2 · DESIGN THE STRUCTURE

THE AI STRATEGY CANVAS

Before you create a single folder, fill in the AI Strategy Canvas — the nine-block model from INGRAIN AI. If you attended the session you've done a first pass; if not, block out 45 minutes with the people who know the business best.

THE NINE BLOCKS

#	BLOCK	THE QUESTION IT ANSWERS
1	Target Audience	Who do you serve?
2	Company	Who are you?
3	Products / Services	What do you offer?
4	Context	What's going on right now the AI needs to know?
5	Role	What job should the AI play?
6	Style / Brand Voice	How do you sound?
7	Resources	What source material exists?
8	Rules	What must the AI always and never do?
9	Request	What tasks will you actually run?

The reframe that matters: the canvas isn't a workshop artefact, it's a **schema**. Every block becomes a home in your folder tree. The canvas stops being a poster and becomes a directory.

PART 2 · DESIGN THE STRUCTURE

THE BLOCK-TO-FOLDER MAP

CANVAS BLOCK	WHERE IT LIVES IN THE CORTEX
Company	company/profile.md , company/divisions.md
Products / Services	company/offerings.md
Target Audience	clients/ (one file per client or segment)
Context	processes/ and decisions/
Role	CLAUDE.md (top section)
Style / Brand Voice	company/brand-voice.md
Resources	The whole repo, plus resources/
Rules	CLAUDE.md (rules section)
Request	skills/ (one folder per repeatable task)

THE REFERENCE TREE

This is the shape, using Hawthorne Racing (a fictional F1 constructor) as the worked example:

```
hawthorne-racing/  
  CLAUDE.md  
  01-global/  
    01-context/ 02-skills/ 03-data/  
    04-automations/ 05-deliverables/  
  02-workspaces/  
    01-commercial/  
      01-context/ 02-skills/ 03-data/  
      04-automations/ 05-deliverables/  
    02-race-operations/  
      01-context/ 02-skills/ 03-data/  
      04-automations/ 05-deliverables/  
  03-personal/
```

Swap 01-commercial/ for clients/ , suppliers/ , or whatever dimension best segments your workspaces. Boring, predictable names beat clever ones — your newest hire and your AI agent both need to guess where things live.

README.md is the front door for humans (what this Cortex is, who owns it, how to contribute). **CLAUDE.md** is the front door for the AI — it holds the Role and Rules blocks and is read automatically at the start of every session.

PART 3 · CHOOSE YOUR PATH

PATH A · BUILD FROM SCRATCH

Use this if you're designing your own structure from your canvas.

A1 – CREATE THE FOLDER

```
mkdir C:\Users\%USERNAME%\YourCortexName
```

A2 – INITIALISE GIT

```
cd C:\Users\%USERNAME%\YourCortexName
git init
```

A3 – BUILD THE SKELETON FROM YOUR CANVAS

```
mkdir strategy company clients processes decisions skills
```

Then create your first files: a three-line `README.md` (what it is, who owns it, how to contribute) and a `CLAUDE.md` with your Role and Rules in plain sentences. Drop your canvas into `strategy/ai-strategy-canvas.md` and write one real `company/` profile.

A4 – FIRST COMMIT

```
git add -A
git commit -m "Initial Cortex structure from AI Strategy Canvas"
```

A5 – PUT IT ON GITHUB

1. Go to `https://github.com/new` and name the repo the same as your folder.
2. Set it to **Private**.
3. **Do not** tick "Add a README", ".gitignore", or a license – the repo must be empty.
4. Click Create repository, then back in your terminal:

```
git remote add origin https://github.com/YOUR-USERNAME/YourCortexName.git
git branch -M main
git push -u origin main
```

The first push opens a browser to sign in. Approve it, refresh the repo page, and your files should be there. Your Cortex now exists in two places, kept in sync by Git. **Go to Part 4.**

PART 3 · CHOOSE YOUR PATH

PATH B · START FROM THE TEMPLATE

Use this if you'd rather refill a proven structure than design your own. The template is the same Hawthorne Racing demo Cortex shown in the session.

Template repo: <https://github.com/Arbitrco/hawthorne-racing-demo>

B1 – COPY THE TEMPLATE INTO YOUR OWN ACCOUNT

1. Open the template repo on GitHub.
2. Click the green **Use this template** button, then **Create a new repository**.
3. Name it, set it to **Private**, click Create.

If the green button says **Code** instead of **Use this template**, use this fallback, then create an empty private repo and push as in A5:

```
cd C:\Users\%USERNAME%
git clone https://github.com/[HAWTHORNE-REPO-URL] YourCortexName
cd YourCortexName
rmdir /s /q .git
git init
git add -A
git commit -m "Initial Cortex from Hawthorne template"
```

B2 – PULL IT TO YOUR MACHINE (TEMPLATE-BUTTON PATH)

```
cd C:\Users\%USERNAME%
git clone https://github.com/YOUR-USERNAME/YourCortexName.git
cd YourCortexName
```

B3 – EVICT HAWTHORNE, MOVE YOURSELF IN

1. Rewrite `CLAUDE.md` with your Role and Rules — this one matters most.
2. Replace `company/profile.md`, `divisions.md`, `brand-voice.md` with your own.
3. Rename `partners/` to whatever fits, and replace the contents.
4. Delete the example decisions and processes (or keep one as a formatting reference).
5. Keep the `skills/` folders — read before deleting. The meeting-decision-analyst skill fits any organisation that holds meetings.
6. Drop your canvas into `strategy/ai-strategy-canvas.md`, commit as you go, and **go to Part 4**.

PART 3 · CHOOSE YOUR PATH

PATH C · JOIN AN EXISTING CORTEX

Use this if your organisation already runs a Cortex and you need it on your machine.

C1 – GET ACCESS

Ask the Cortex owner to add you as a collaborator (GitHub → **Settings** → **Collaborators and teams**). Accept the email invitation.

C2 – CLONE IT

1. Open the repo page on GitHub, click the green **Code** button, copy the HTTPS URL.
2. In your terminal:

```
cd C:\Users\%USERNAME%
git clone https://github.com/YOUR-ORG/CortexName.git
cd CortexName
```

The first clone of a private repo asks you to sign in through your browser – approve it once. Verify with `git status` ; you should see "On branch main" and a clean working tree.

C3 – LEARN THE HOUSE RULES

1. Read `README.md` – how this Cortex is organised and how to contribute.
2. Read `CLAUDE.md` – the rules everyone (and the AI) works under.
3. Respect ownership: update your own team's context freely; changes to another team's files go through that team's owner first.

C4 – THE SYNC HABIT

Pull before you start, push when you finish. That's the entire discipline:

```
git pull
# ... do your work ...
git add -A
git commit -m "Describe what changed"
git push
```

Miss the pull and you edit stale files; miss the push and your work helps nobody but you. **Go to Part 4.**

PART 4 · WIRE IN CLAUDE CODE

Everyone does this part, whichever path you took.

STEP 1 – INSTALL GRAPHIFY

graphify builds a knowledge graph of your Cortex so Claude understands how everything connects without reading every file every time.

```
pip install graphify
```

Then run it inside your Cortex:

```
cd C:\Users\%USERNAME%\YourCortexName
python -m graphify .
```

This creates a `graphify-out/` folder Claude Code uses automatically. Re-run it whenever the structure changes significantly.

STEP 2 – SET UP TERMINAL ALIASES

Aliases launch Claude Code with a short command from anywhere. **cr** (Claude Run) launches full-auto mode – your daily driver. **cs** (Claude Safe) launches with permission prompts so you review each action.

1. Open PowerShell (search "PowerShell" in the Start menu).
2. Create your profile file if it doesn't exist and open it:

```
if (!(Test-Path -Path $PROFILE)) { New-Item -ItemType File -Path $PROFILE -Force }
notepad $PROFILE
```

Paste this at the bottom, save, then close and reopen PowerShell:

```
function cs {
    Write-Host "Starting Claude (safe mode)..." -ForegroundColor Cyan
    claude
}

function cr {
    Write-Host "Starting Claude (full auto mode)..." -ForegroundColor Yellow
    claude --dangerously-skip-permissions
}
```

PART 4 · WIRE IN CLAUDE CODE

Test it by typing `cr` and pressing Enter — you should see "Starting Claude (full auto mode)...".

If you get an execution-policy error, run this once as Administrator, then reopen PowerShell:

```
Set-ExecutionPolicy RemoteSigned -Scope CurrentUser
```

What the flag means: `--dangerously-skip-permissions` lets Claude read files, write files, and run commands without asking first — that's what makes `cr` fast. Only use it in your own Cortex on your own computer. In a shared Cortex when you're new, start with `cs` until you trust what's happening.

STEP 3 – LAUNCH CLAUDE CODE FOR THE FIRST TIME

```
cd C:\Users\%USERNAME%\YourCortexName
cs
```

The first run asks you to authenticate — follow the browser prompts (once only). When the prompt is waiting for input, try:

Read CLAUDE.md and company/profile.md, then tell me what this organisation does in two sentences.

If the answer comes back accurate, your Cortex is alive — the AI just briefed itself from your files, with nobody re-typing anything. Type `/exit` to quit.

THE DAILY RHYTHM

From here, every session looks the same:

1. Open your terminal and `cd` into your Cortex.
2. `git pull` (if you share the Cortex with others).
3. Launch with `cr` and do the work.
4. `git add -A`, `git commit -m "what changed"`, `git push`.

The canvas was a cost you paid once for a feeling. The Cortex is an asset that pays out every day — and every session makes it a little richer.

REFERENCE

TROUBLESHOOTING

"git is not recognized" / "command not found"

Close your terminal and open a new one. If it still fails, restart your computer – the installer needs a fresh terminal to register.

"node is not recognized"

Same fix: close the terminal, open a new one, restart if needed.

"npm ERR!" during Claude Code install

Run the terminal as Administrator and retry `npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code`.

"python is not recognized"

You missed the "Add to PATH" checkbox during install. Reinstall Python and check that box.

"Permission denied" / "Repository not found" when cloning or pushing

Either you haven't accepted the collaborator invitation (check your email), or you're signed in to the wrong GitHub account. Run `git config user.email` to see which identity Git is using.

Push rejected with "fetch first"

Someone pushed since your last pull. Run `git pull`, resolve anything Git flags, then push again – the "pull first" habit earning its keep.

Claude Code asks for an API key

You need a Claude Pro subscription at claude.ai. Claude Code uses your Pro account, not a separate API key – follow the authentication prompts.

graphify fails to install

Confirm Python works first (`python --version`). If pip is not found, try `python -m pip install graphify`.

Questions, or want help designing the structure for your organisation? hello@arbitr.co



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Hawthorne Racing is a demo / scenario brand. Cortex Setup Guide - July 2026.

